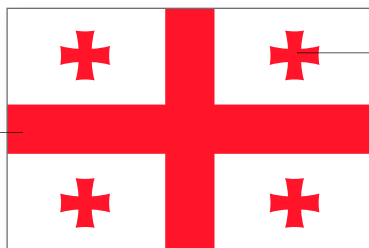


Georgia

Ratio: 3:5 **Adopted:** January 14, 2004 **Usage:** National and Civil

*Red cross, typical of
St. George, Georgia's
patron saint*



*Smaller crosses,
possibly based on the
“Jerusalem” cross*

Asia



Georgia was absorbed into the Russian Empire in 1801 and became part of the Soviet Union in 1921. It regained independence in 1991.

During the “Rose Revolution” of 2003, the Georgian flag achieved prominence as the symbol of the opposition National Movement. On taking power in 2004 the party adopted it as the new national flag.

OBSCURE ORIGINS

The historical background of the flag is uncertain. References are made in a 14th-century text to a similar flag from Sivas, in modern Turkey. Georgians may have adopted it after invading the territory.

Another theory suggests Georgian links with the Holy Land saw the addition of the four small crosses. These were based on the “Jerusalem” cross. However, it is true that

St. George is the patron saint of Georgia, perhaps explaining the basic red cross on a white field.

THE SOVIET ERA

While part of the USSR, Georgia flew a variant of the Red Flag, adopted in 1951. It had a red field, with a thin blue stripe close to the top. The canton contained the traditional hammer, sickle, and star emblems, unusually in red, on a blue disc from which emanated 24 rays.

Following independence from the USSR in 1991, Georgia officially re-adopted a flag used during its brief independence between 1918 and 1921. The field was deep red, with black and white stripes in the canton.